

Student Manual for ChatGPT and the Codex Desktop App

How to prompt, study responsibly, and use Goals, skills, plugins, MCP, and app commands

This manual helps students use ChatGPT as a thoughtful study partner rather than a quick-answer machine. It covers ordinary prompts and the advanced controls in the ChatGPT and Codex desktop app. The examples suit university work, but the habits apply to any learning task.

What you will be able to do

- Write prompts that produce useful, checkable study help.
- Use files, images, web search, and feedback without losing academic ownership.
- Organize coursework in projects and separate chats.
- Use app commands such as `/plan`, `/goal`, `/status`, and `/mcp`.
- Understand when skills, plugins, automations, and MCP connections are useful and when they need extra care.

Availability note. The app changes over time, and some features depend on your device, plan, organization policy, selected project, or installed integrations. If a command does not appear after you type `/`, it is not available in the current chat. The command list inside the app is the source of truth.

Core principle. Ask ChatGPT to help you think, check, practise, organize, and improve. Do not use it to submit work you do not understand or cannot explain. Your course rules and instructor directions always come first.

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1 Start with a good prompt

A prompt is an instruction or question. You do not need special syntax. For a larger or important task, give ChatGPT enough information to understand the task and enough boundaries to avoid an unhelpful answer.

Part	What to say	Example
Goal	The result you want	Explain the main idea in this chapter.
Context	Relevant course level, source, data, or assignment brief	I am a first-year business student. Use this case study.
Output	Format, length, voice, or structure	Use a six-bullet summary and a five-question quiz.
Boundaries	What to preserve, avoid, verify, or ask about	Do not invent sources. Flag claims that need checking.

A flexible prompt template

Help me [goal].

Context: [course level, source, assignment, or data].

Output: [format, length, audience].

Constraints: [what to preserve, avoid, verify, or ask before changing].

Three strong student prompts

Explain this economics concept as if I am revising for an exam.

Give one concrete example, then test me with three short questions.

Correct my answers only after I try.

Read the attached article. Separate its main claim, evidence, assumptions, and limitations. Tell me which points I should verify in the original paper.

I have drafted this paragraph. Keep my argument and voice, but show three revisions: clarity, evidence, and structure. Explain why each revision is stronger so I can choose it myself.

Useful follow-ups include: “make this simpler”, “give a counterargument”, “turn this into flashcards”, “compare this with the lecture notes”, and “ask me questions instead of giving the answer”.

2 Everyday study workflows

Learn a new topic

Start broad, then narrow. Ask for a plain-language explanation, one example, common misconceptions, and a short self-test. Ask the model to adapt when something is too simple or too technical.

Read critically

Upload or paste a source and ask for a map of its claim, evidence, methods, assumptions, and limits. Then compare that map with the original. ChatGPT can help you notice structure; it does not replace reading the source carefully.

Prepare for assessment

Use practice questions, oral-exam simulations, flashcards, marking rubrics, and feedback on your own answers. A useful instruction is: “Give one question at a time. Wait for my answer. Then give feedback using this rubric.”

Write and revise

Use ChatGPT after you have an idea, evidence, and a draft. Ask for an outline, a reverse outline, paragraph-level feedback, transitions, or citation checks. Keep a version of your own work so you can judge every suggested change.

Work with data and code

Ask it to explain a method, inspect a formula, draft code, diagnose an error, or help you design tests. Always run the work yourself and check inputs, assumptions, results, and citations. A plausible-looking chart or program can still be wrong.

Use current information carefully

When the task relies on current facts, explicitly ask for web search and sources. Read the sources, check publication dates, and distinguish a source’s evidence from ChatGPT’s summary or interpretation.

A practical learning loop

Stage	What you do	A useful request
Attempt	Try the problem or reading first	Do not solve it yet. Ask me three guiding questions.
Compare	Check your thinking	Here is my answer. Identify one strength and one gap.
Practise	Retrieve from memory	Quiz me with mixed-difficulty questions.
Reflect	Plan the next step	What should I review next, based on my mistakes?

3 Academic integrity and source checking

ChatGPT can make mistakes, summarize a source incorrectly, or create references that look real but are not. Treat every output as a draft or starting point, not as evidence by itself.

Use this checklist before submitting work

- Can I explain the main idea, method, and conclusion in my own words?
- Did I read and cite the original sources rather than citing a chatbot answer?
- Did I check quotations, data, calculations, and references against reliable sources?
- Does the work follow my course policy on AI use and disclosure?
- Did I remove personal, confidential, or restricted information that I was not allowed to share?
- If ChatGPT changed my writing, did I accept only changes I understand and can defend?

Instead of	Try
Write my essay	Help me create an outline from these sources. Ask me for my position before drafting any paragraph.
Give me references	Suggest search terms and databases. Do not invent citations; give links only when you can verify them.
Solve this assignment	Explain the method, then give me a similar practice problem. Do not reveal the answer until I attempt it.
Make this sound academic	Keep my meaning. Identify unclear claims and places where evidence or a citation is needed.

Privacy basics

Do not paste passwords, private grades, personal health information, unpublished research data, confidential internship material, or another person's private messages unless you have explicit permission and your institution's rules allow it. When in doubt, remove names and identifiers or ask your instructor or supervisor.

4 Projects and chats in the desktop app

The desktop app can be used for ordinary ChatGPT conversations and, where available, Codex work. In this manual, *app commands* means the slash commands typed in the message composer. They are shortcuts for changing how the current chat works or opening a related app control.

Use a project for a course, research stream, or multi-part assignment. A project can keep related chats, uploaded files, instructions, connected sources, and, for local projects, folders on your computer together. Start a separate chat for each distinct outcome, such as “read week 4 article”, “build flashcards”, or “review draft introduction”.

Use	Best for	Student example
A chat	One focused outcome	Turn one lecture into a revision quiz.
A project	Several related chats sharing context	A dissertation project with sources, drafts, and feedback chats.
A local project	Files or code in a folder on your computer	A programming assignment repository.
A temporary or standalone chat	A self-contained question with no shared material	Clarify one statistics formula.

Helpful macOS shortcuts

Action	Shortcut
New chat	Cmd N
Open command menu	Cmd Shift P or Cmd K
Open settings	Cmd comma
Open keyboard-shortcut list	Cmd slash
Find text in the current chat	Cmd F
Toggle sidebar	Cmd B
Open a folder in Codex or Work	Cmd O
Choose model	Control Shift M

Windows and Linux shortcuts may differ. Open Settings and then Keyboard Shortcuts to see or customize what is available on your device.

5 Slash commands in the app

Type `/` in the chat composer and choose a command from the list. The list is context-aware, so it may show fewer commands than this manual. Type `$` to explicitly invoke an available skill. A custom prompt can appear as `/prompts:name`.

Planning and progress

Command	What it does	When a student might use it
<code>/plan</code>	Enters planning mode for a multi-step task.	Turn a vague dissertation task into a sequence of deliverables.
<code>/goal</code>	Sets a persistent objective for the chat to work toward.	Finish a study guide with sources, self-test, and review checklist.
<code>/status</code>	Shows chat ID, context use, and rate-limit information.	Check the state of a long research or coding chat.
<code>/compact</code>	Compacts the current chat context.	Keep a long chat usable after saving key outcomes elsewhere.
<code>/side</code>	Starts a temporary side chat without interrupting the main chat.	Check a definition while keeping an essay-review chat focused.

Where the work runs

Command	What it does	Use with care
<code>/project</code>	Chooses a project for new chats.	Choose the correct course project before sharing files.
<code>/task</code>	Starts a chat without a project.	Good for a small, unrelated question.
<code>/local</code>	Runs the chat in the selected local project.	Allows work with the attached local folder and its permissions.
<code>/cloud</code> or <code>/cloud-environment</code>	Uses cloud execution or chooses its environment when available.	Check what files and services the selected environment can access.
<code>/worktree</code> or <code>/fork</code>	Uses a separate Git worktree or copies a local chat.	Useful for code experiments; avoid two chats editing the same files.

6 More app commands

Command	What it does	Student use
<code>/model</code>	Chooses the model for the current chat.	Use the model your institution or account makes available; do not assume all models have the same strengths.
<code>/reasoning</code>	Chooses reasoning effort for the current chat.	Use more effort for difficult analysis when available; still verify the result.
<code>/review</code>	Starts code-review mode for local changes or a comparison branch.	Ask for a review of a programming assignment before you submit it.
<code>/init</code>	Generates an <code>AGENTS.md</code> scaffold for the current project.	For coding projects, create reusable instructions such as test commands and style rules.
<code>/ide-context</code>	Turns shared IDE context on or off.	Use it only when you want the editor's current files to inform the chat.
<code>/memories</code>	Controls whether the chat can use or generate memories, when available.	Review the setting before discussing personal learning preferences.
<code>/personality</code>	Chooses how Codex responds, when supported.	A clearer teaching style can help, but it does not change factual reliability.
<code>/feedback</code>	Opens feedback and can include logs.	Report an app problem without posting private course material publicly.
<code>/approve</code>	Approves one retry after an automatic-review denial, when enabled.	Read the request first; approval can allow a tool action that was previously blocked.

A useful planning prompt

`/plan`

I need to prepare a 10-minute presentation from these three readings.

Interview me about the audience and marking criteria, then propose a plan.

Do not write the slides until I approve the outline.

7 Goals for long-running work

A Goal is a durable objective. In the desktop app, type `/goal` to start Goal mode. The goal text becomes both the first prompt and the completion criteria. While it runs, the progress row lets you pause, resume, edit, or clear the goal; you can still send follow-up messages to steer it.

Element	Include	Example
Outcome	A finished result, not just activity	Create a revision guide for weeks 1 to 5.
Constraints	Boundaries, required sources, and things to avoid	Use only my uploaded lecture notes. Do not invent facts.
Verification	A test, review criterion, or evidence of completion	Include 20 practice questions and flag every claim needing a source check.

`/goal`

Create an exam revision pack from the attached lecture notes. Use only those notes. Include a one-page concept map, 20 mixed-difficulty practice questions with answers in a separate section, and a list of topics I should re-read. Mark ambiguous points for me to verify.
Done means every lecture topic appears at least once and the output is ready for review.

Use `/goal` for a task with several steps and a clear final result. Use `/plan` first if you do not yet know the correct scope or completion criteria. Keep related material in one chat, and do not let two active chats change the same local files.

8 MCP and connectors

MCP means Model Context Protocol. It connects ChatGPT or Codex to outside tools and context, such as documentation, a browser, Figma, Drive, Slack, or a specialist system. An MCP server defines tools, authentication, and the data or actions it can expose.

Term	What it means	Example
MCP server	A service that offers tools or context to the app.	A local documentation server or remote research-data service.
Connector	A ready-made connection to an external service.	A connection to Google Drive or Slack.
Plugin	An installable package that may include skills, connectors, MCP tools, hooks, or a user interface.	A Drive plugin that adds document workflows.
<code>/mcp</code>	Opens MCP status and shows connected servers.	Check that a required server is connected before asking it to use data.

How to connect an MCP server in the desktop app

1. Open *Settings*, then select *MCP servers*.
2. Select *Add server*.
3. Enter a name, choose *STDIO* or *Streamable HTTP*, and enter the trusted provider's command or URL.
4. Save the server, then restart if the app asks.
5. Authenticate if required, then type `/mcp` in a chat to check status.

Safety rules for MCP

Only add servers from people, organizations, or course projects you trust. Read what access a server requests. Do not enter passwords, API keys, or confidential data into a server you have not verified. An MCP server can read information or perform actions through its tools, so treat it like installing software or granting a new app permission.

9 Skills and plugins

A skill is a reusable set of instructions for a type of work. A plugin is an installable bundle of capabilities. It can contain skills, connectors, MCP servers, browser extensions, hooks, or scheduled-task templates. In the desktop app, use the *Plugins* tab to browse and install plugins; then begin a new chat to use newly installed capabilities.

Need	Use	Example request
One-off instruction	A normal prompt	Create 12 flashcards from this reading.
Repeated specialist work-flow	A skill	<code>\$skill-name</code> turn these notes into an exam-revision pack.
External data or actions	A connector or MCP server	Use my connected Drive to find the class briefing document.
A packaged capability	A plugin	Use the installed spreadsheet plugin to inspect this CSV.
A recurring check	A scheduled task or automation	Every Friday, remind me to review this project plan.

Install a plugin carefully

1. Open the *Plugins* tab, search or browse, and read the details.
2. Install the plugin with the plus button.
3. Connect an external service only if you trust it and actually need it.
4. Start a new chat and ask the app to use the plugin.
5. Review every permission request and the plugin's access before approving actions.

Skills improve process guidance; they do not guarantee correctness. Continue to check sources, calculations, and course rules. If a skill is not available, a clear normal prompt can often describe the same workflow.

10 Automations and scheduled tasks

Scheduled tasks run a saved prompt in the background at a regular time. The desktop app can use local projects for scheduled tasks, but the computer must be on and the app must be running when the task needs local files. The Scheduled area lets you review active, paused, completed tasks, and recent runs.

Task	Saved prompt idea	Check first
Weekly revision reminder	Every Sunday, ask me to choose three topics from this project to review next week.	The timing is useful.
Reading-plan check	Every Friday, compare my checklist with the reading schedule and list unfinished items.	The checklist is in an accessible project or connected service.
Research watch	Each month, look for new peer-reviewed articles on this defined topic and return links and dates.	Search terms are specific and sources will be verified.
Code maintenance	Each week, run the project test instructions and report failures without changing code.	The project is safe to access and test commands are appropriate.

Set up a reliable scheduled task

1. Test the prompt in an ordinary chat first.
2. State the result, source of context, and what counts as a useful notification.
3. Use a cadence that matches the task; more frequent is not automatically better.
4. Review the first few runs and improve the prompt if the output is vague or noisy.
5. Keep recurring tasks quiet when nothing meaningful has changed.

Availability of scheduled and event-triggered tasks depends on plan, workspace, and platform. Do not assume an automation can access a local folder, file, or external service unless the app shows that access is enabled.

11 Files, images, web, and voice

Files and images

Attach a document, spreadsheet, presentation, PDF, image, or screenshot when it is the real source for the task. Tell ChatGPT what to use it for and point to the important section. For example: “Compare pages 3 to 5 with this rubric and list missing evidence.”

Web search

Ask for web search when facts may have changed or when you need sources. Request links and publication dates. Then open the sources yourself, especially for academic claims, policy, health, law, finance, or current events.

Image generation

Use image generation for study diagrams, concept illustrations, poster ideas, or presentation visuals. Check that any image is appropriate for the course, label AI-generated visuals if required, and do not present generated images as documentary evidence.

Voice

Voice chat can be useful for oral-exam practice, language learning, or explaining a difficult concept aloud. Ask the app to role-play an examiner, pause after each answer, and provide short feedback. Do not share sensitive information in a voice session.

Use the attached lecture slides to create a revision outline.
For each topic, give: key idea, one example from the slides, one likely exam question, and one point I should verify in the original material.
Do not use outside sources unless I ask.

12 Quick command guide

Command	Plain-language purpose
<code>/plan</code>	Plan a complex task before doing it.
<code>/goal</code>	Set a persistent objective and completion criteria.
<code>/status</code>	Check chat details, context, and rate limits.
<code>/compact</code>	Condense the current chat context.
<code>/project</code> or <code>/task</code>	Choose a project or start without one.
<code>/local</code> , <code>/cloud-environment</code>	<code>/cloud</code> , Choose where the chat runs, when available.
<code>/worktree</code> or <code>/fork</code>	Separate coding work or copy a chat.
<code>/mcp</code>	View connected MCP servers.
<code>/model</code> or <code>/reasoning</code>	Choose the model or reasoning effort for this chat.
<code>/review</code>	Review local code changes.
<code>/init</code>	Scaffold <code>AGENTS.md</code> project guidance.
<code>/side</code>	Open a temporary side chat.
<code>/memories</code> or <code>/personality</code>	Manage personalization features when available.
<code>/feedback</code> or <code>/approve</code>	Send feedback or approve a retry after a safety review.
<code>\$skill-name</code>	Explicitly invoke an available skill.

Five habits worth keeping

- State the result you need before prescribing every step.
- Share only the context that changes the answer.
- Ask for sources when a claim depends on current or external information.
- Use `/plan` for ambiguity and `/goal` for a clear, multi-step outcome.

- Read every permission request before an integration, plugin, MCP server, or tool takes action.

13 Glossary and official help

Term	Meaning
Chat	One conversation with its own messages and context.
Project	A place that groups related chats, files, instructions, and sources.
Goal	A persistent objective for long-running work in a chat.
Slash command	A command typed with / in the message composer.
Skill	Reusable instructions for a particular kind of work.
Plugin	An installable package that can add skills, tools, connectors, and more.
Connector	An authorized connection to an external service.
MCP	Model Context Protocol; a way to connect the app to tools and context.
Automation	A task that runs on a schedule or supported event.
AGENTS.md	Project guidance file used by Codex for durable instructions in a codebase.

Official OpenAI documentation

Use official documentation when a feature, command, or permission matters. These pages were consulted for this manual:

- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/prompting>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/projects>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/long-running-work>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/automations>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/plugins>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/extend/mcp>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/reference/commands>
- <https://learn.chatgpt.com/docs/reference/slash-commands>

Final reminder. The strongest use of ChatGPT is active learning: ask, attempt, challenge, verify, and revise. Keep responsibility for your decisions, sources, and submitted work with you.